bureaucrat when I had casually mentioned my conversation with Sharma. Now, the audio tapes had revived the story.

That the Snoopgate 'revelations' were met with some scepticism perhaps reflected the credibility crisis afflicting the ruling UPA government. In normal times, the audio tapes would have merited a detailed investigation, with tough questions being asked. But in the build-up to the elections, it was perceived as yet another 'hit job' on Modi and his man Friday. Had the Snoopgate story broken a year or two earlier, it might have resonated more strongly. The UPA had got its timing wrong—yet again.

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As 2013 was winding down, Narendra Modi and Amit Shah were in a celebratory mood. Snoopgate hadn't taken off. The CNN-IBN election tracker was showing the BJP making steady progress and well ahead of the Congress nationwide. Modi's rallies were attracting a huge response, and the key states of UP and Bihar both seemed to be in control. Mission 272-plus was no longer unattainable.

But politics in India always has a surprise around the corner. Just as Shah and Modi were preparing to rejoice at a turnaround 2013, a new X factor emerged. Another pretender ready to challenge the front runners burst onto the scene. Arvind Kejriwal and his Aam Aadmi Party had just taken Delhi by storm. The battle for 2014 wasn't over just yet.